SUPPLEMENTAL WORKBOOK

indistractable

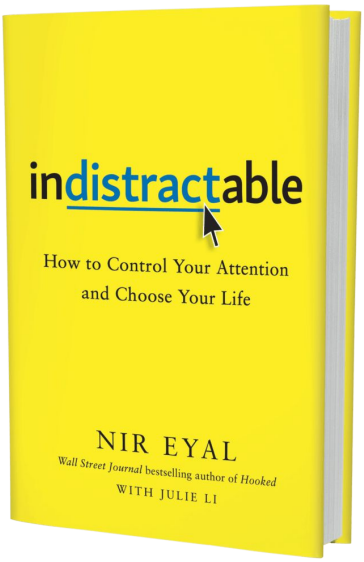
How to Control Your Attention and Choose Your Life

NIR EYAL

Wall Street Journal bestselling author of *Hooked*

WITH JULIE LI

Special Offer



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Early Praise For Indistractable

If you value your time, your focus, or your relationships, this book is essential reading. I'm putting these ideas into practice.

-*Prof*. Jonathan Haidt, author, *The Righteous Mind*

"Being indistractable is the essential skill for our time. Skip this book at your peril! My advice is this: Read it. Live it. Repeat."

Greg McKeown, author of *Essentialism*

"This book has done more to change the way I see the world than anything I've read in the past several years. The actionable insights from Indistractable have helped me reduce my daily time spent on email by 90%."

Shane Snow, author of *Smartcuts*

"This is such an important book. Indistractable is the best guide I've read for reclaiming our attention, our focus, and our lives."

Arianna Huffington, Founder & CEO, Thrive Global and Founder, The Huffington Post

"As a lifelong procrastinator, I'm painfully aware of how much productivity-related advice there is out there and how little of it is actually helpful. Indistractable *is an exception."*

Tim Urban, author of WaitButWhy.com

Early Praise For Indistractable

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Introduction

Note from the Author:

Over the years, I've learned a multitude of hacks, strategies, tips, and tricks, all designed to improve or uplevel my life in one way or the other. I'm sure you've heard about a few of them: *Start a morning routine! Delete Facebook! Drink yak milk while standing on one foot!*

While these tips can be helpful, (well, except for that last one) there is one universally powerful truth at the root of achieving our biggest goals: living the life we want requires not only doing the *right* things but also necessitates *not* doing the things that take us off-track.

Imagine the incredible power of actually following through on your intentions.

How much more effective would you be at work? How much more time could you spend with your family? How much happier would you be?

In this workbook, you'll practice the key lessons I teach in each chapter of my book, Indistractable: How to Control Your Attention and Choose Your Life.

It is only by actively reflecting on the principles you learn and putting them into practice that you can expect them to change your life.

I wish you the very best as you become indistractable!

Nir Eyal
NirAndFar.com

What's Your Superpower?

Remember this:

- ❑ **We need to learn how to avoid distraction.**
  Living the lives we want not only requires doing the right things but also necessitates not doing the things we know we'll regret.

- ❑ **The problem is deeper than tech.**
  Being indistractable is about understanding the real reasons why we do things against our best interests.

- ❑ **Here's what it takes:**
  We can be indistractable by learning and adopting four key strategies: mastering internal triggers, hacking back external triggers, making time for traction, and preventing distraction with pacts.

Note: Make sure you read the introduction and first chapter of Indistractable to fully understand these concepts before completing the exercises.

Exercise 1

1. What would life be like if you were indistractable? Write down some specific ways your life would improve.

Being Indistractable

Remember this:

- ❑ **Distraction stops you from achieving your goals.**
  It is any action that moves you away from what you really want.

- ❑ **Traction leads you closer to your goals.**
  It is any action that moves you toward what you really want.

- ❑ **Triggers prompt both traction and distraction.**
  External triggers prompt you to action with cues in your environment. Internal triggers prompt you to action with cues within you.

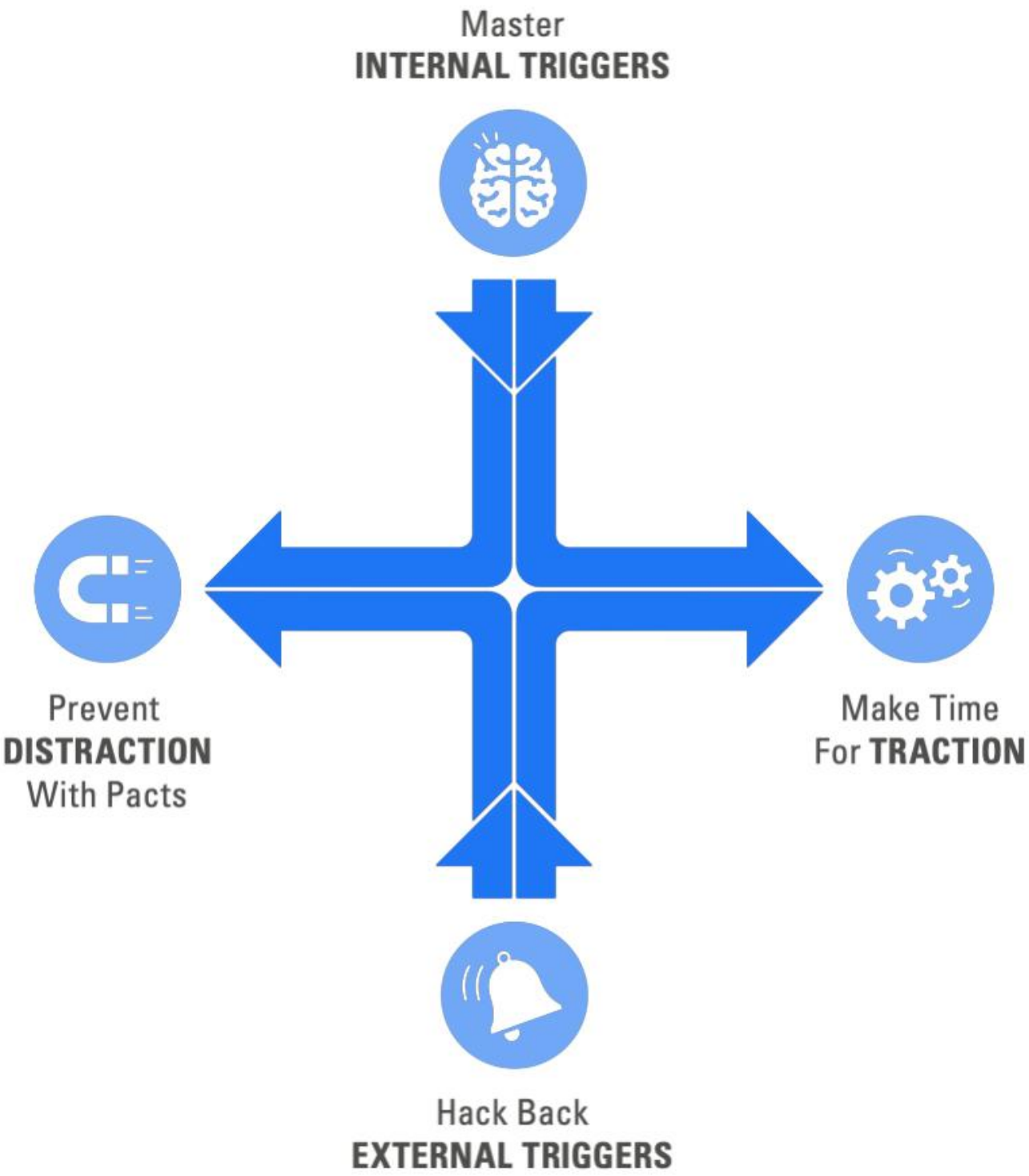
Note: Make sure you read the second chapter of Indistractable to fully understand these concepts before completing the exercises.

Exercise 2

1. Name one thing you did today that moved you closer to what you really wanted (e.g., going to the gym, focusing on an important task at work, etc.) and the benefit you received from that action (e.g., living healthfully, helping my team close a sale).

2. Name one thing you did today that moved you away from what you really wanted (e.g., wasting time online, procrastinating at work, etc.) and the foregone benefit of taking that action (e.g., spending time with someone I love, being a team player at work.)

How to Be Indistractable



from *Indistractable* by Nir Eyal

Part 1:

Master Internal Triggers

What Motivates Us, Really?

Remember this:

- ❑ **Understand the root cause of distraction.**
  Distraction is about more than your devices. Separate proximate causes from the root cause.

- ❑ **All motivation is a desire to escape discomfort.**
  If a behavior was previously effective at providing relief, we're likely to continue using it as a tool to escape discomfort.

- ❑ **Anything that stops discomfort is potentially addictive, but that doesn't make it irresistible.**
  If you know the drivers of your behavior, you can take steps to manage them.

Note: Make sure you read the third chapter of Indistractable to fully understand these concepts before completing the exercises on the following page.

What Motivates Us, Really? (cont.)

Exercise 3

Refer back to the distraction you wrote down in the previous exercise. Write down three root causes of discomfort you may be trying to escape by doing the unwanted behavior. For example, when I was using my phone when I wanted to spend quality time with my daughter, I was trying to escape: 1) the fear that I might be missing out on something important happening at work, 2) the anticipation of a client email, and 3) the boredom that comes from playing with a young child for too long.

Distraction:

Root Cause #1:

Root Cause #2:

Root Cause #3:

Time Management is Pain Management

Remember this:

- ❑ **Time management is pain management.**
  Distractions cost us time, and like all actions, they are spurred by the desire to escape discomfort.

- ❑ **Four psychological factors make satisfaction temporary.**
  Our tendencies toward boredom, negativity bias, rumination, and hedonic adaptation conspire to make sure we're never satisfied for long.

- ❑ **Dissatisfaction is responsible for our species' advancements as much as its faults.**
  It is an innate power that can be channeled to help us make things better. If we want to master distraction, we must learn to deal with discomfort.

Note: Make sure you read the fourth chapter of Indistractable to fully understand these concepts before completing the exercises.

Exercise 4

Name four things you tend to get distracted while doing. Describe what you did to distract yourself.

Task	Distraction
i.e. Working on big project	*i.e. Check email instead of doing real work*

Deal With Distraction From Within

Remember this:

- ❑ **Without techniques for disarming temptation, mental abstinence can backfire.**
  Resisting an urge can trigger rumination and make the desire grow stronger.

- ❑ **We can manage distractions that originate from within by changing how we think about them.**
  We can reimagine the trigger, the task, and our temperament.

Note: Make sure you read the fifth chapter of Indistractable to fully understand these concepts before completing the exercises.

Exercise 5

Recall one incident when mental abstinence (i.e. "just saying no") backfired, leaving you further away from what you really wanted. *I.e. When I went on an extreme diet, I gained back all the weight and then some.*

Reimagine The Internal Trigger

Remember this:

- **By reimagining an uncomfortable internal trigger, we can disarm it.**

  Step 1: Look for the emotion preceding distraction.

  Step 2: Write down the internal trigger. (Use the Distraction Tracker included in the book and bonus bundle)

  Step 3: Explore the negative sensation with curiosity instead of contempt.

  Step 4: Be extra cautious during liminal moments. (Liminal moments are "distraction traps" that transition us from one thing to another, like picking up our phone while waiting for a traffic light to change).

Note: Make sure you read the sixth chapter of Indistractable to fully understand these concepts before completing the exercises.

Exercise 6

1) Refer back to the distraction you wrote down in the earlier exercise, or think of another distraction you frequently deal with.

   What discomfort(s) or internal trigger(s) did you feel immediately prior to the distraction (check all that apply)

☐ Afraid	☐ Frustrated	☐ Bored	☐ Excited
☐ Worried	☐ Angry	☐ Nervous	☐ Insecure
☐ Overwhelmed	☐ Hungry	☐ Sad	☐ Anxious
☐ Lonely	☐ Embarrassed	☐ Guilty	☐ Pressured
☐ Jealous	☐ Tired	☐ Confused	☐ Resentful

Other: _____

Reimagine The Internal Trigger (cont.)

2) What observations can you make about yourself when you feel the internal trigger(s) you checked off above? Be sure to avoid placing judgment on your actions. Simply state your observations of the senses. (*i.e. When I feel stressed, I tend to scroll news headlines.*)

When I feel _____,

I tend to _____.

When I feel _____,

I tend to _____.

When I feel _____,

I tend to _____.

3) Name a few 'liminal moments' in your day, during which you transitioned from one thing to the next, only to find yourself getting distracted? (*i.e. between meetings, at a red light, in the bathroom*)

1.

2.

3.

Reimagine The Task

Remember this:

- ❑ **We can master internal triggers by reimagining an otherwise dreary task.**
  Fun and play can be used as tools to keep us focused.

- ❑ **Play doesn't have to be pleasurable.**
  It just has to hold our attention.

- ❑ **Deliberateness and novelty can be added to any task to make it fun.**

Note: Make sure you read the seventh chapter of Indistractable to fully understand these concepts before completing the exercises.

Exercise 7

1) Describe one frequent task you have to do that you see as boring (e.g., going to the gym, responding to emails, filling out paperwork).

2) Now it's time to move beyond the boredom. What can you do to reimagine the task to make it feel more like play? What small challenges, constraints, or novelty can you add to make it fun?

Reimagine Your Temperament

Remember this:

- ❑ **Reimagining our temperament can help us manage our internal triggers.**
- ❑ **We don't run out of willpower.**
  Believing we do makes us less likely to accomplish our goals by providing a rationale to quit when we could otherwise persist.
- ❑ **What we say to ourselves matters.**
  Labeling yourself as having poor self-control is self-defeating.
- ❑ **Practice self-compassion.**
  Talk to yourself the way you'd talk to a friend. People who are more self-compassionate are more resilient.

Note: Make sure you read the eighth chapter of Indistractable to fully understand these concepts before completing the exercises.

Exercise 8

1) Do you harbor any self-defeating beliefs about your abilities? Do you ever tell yourself you have a "short attention span" or have an "addictive personality"? Write down any labels you attach to yourself and consider whether they are actually serving you.

Reimagine Your Temperament (cont.)

2) How would you respond to a good friend who has experienced a setback? Write down what you would say to them if they failed to do something you tend to get distracted doing.

3) How does your response to yourself at moments of setback or failure make you feel about yourself? Are you able to console yourself with the same words you'd offer a friend?

4) Self-compassion makes us more resilient to let-downs by breaking the vicious cycle of stress that often accompanies failure. How can you change your future response to yourself to be more self-compassionate?

Part 2:

Make Time For Traction

Turn Values Into Time

Remember this:

- ❑ **You can't call something a distraction unless you know what it is distracting you from.**
  Planning ahead is the only way to know the difference between traction and distraction.

- ❑ **Does your calendar reflect your values?**
  To be the person you want to be, you have to make time to live your values.

- ❑ **Timebox your day.**
  The three life domains of you, relationships, and work provide a framework for planning how to spend your time.

- ❑ **Reflect and refine.**
  Revise your schedule regularly, but you must commit to it once it's set.

Note: Make sure you read the ninth chapter of Indistractable to fully understand these concepts before completing the exercises.

Exercise 9

1) Craft your dream "ideal day" on a typical day of the week. What does it look like? How are you spending your time to live up to your values?

2) Compare your dream "ideal day" to your current daily schedule. What could be improved? What are you not making enough time for?

Control The Inputs, Not The Outcomes

Remember this:

- ❑ **Schedule time for yourself first.**
  You are at the center of the three life domains, which are **you, relationships, and work**. Without allocating time for yourself, the other two domains suffer.

- ❑ **Show up when you say you will.**
  You can't always control what you get out of time you spend, but you can control how much time you put into a task.

- ❑ **Input is much more certain than outcome.**
  When it comes to living the life you want, making sure you allocate time to living your values is the only thing you should focus on.

Note: Make sure you read the tenth chapter of Indistractable to fully understand these concepts before completing the exercises.

Exercise 10

1) Name the activities you want to do for yourself every week. List all the things that serve your values of physical health, wellness, and personal growth (e.g., time for sleep, healthy meal preparation, and personal development and learning).

Control The Inputs, Not The Outcomes (cont.)

2) Now that you have your list, note how much time you'd like to allocate for each activity in a typical week.

Activity	Time I'd Like To Allocate Weekly
i.e. exercise	*1 hour every day*

Schedule Important Relationships

Remember this:

- ❑ **The people you love deserve more than getting whatever time is left over.**
  If someone is important to you, make regular time for them on your calendar.

- ❑ **Go beyond scheduling date days with your significant other.**
  Put domestic chores on your calendar to ensure an equitable split.

- ❑ **A lack of close friendships may be hazardous to your health.**
  Ensure you maintain important relationships by scheduling time for regular get-togethers.

Note: Make sure you read the eleventh chapter of Indistractable to fully understand these concepts before completing the exercises.

Exercise 11

1) Name the activities you want to do with or for the important people in your life every week. List all the things that serve your values of connection, closeness, equality, and friendship (e.g., time for playing with your kids, fun time with your significant other, conversations with friends).

Review your list and make sure to include domestic responsibilities, such as tidying-up, preparing meals, shopping for the family, or taking care of finances, as part of your commitment to your important others.

Schedule Important Relationships (cont.)

2) Now that you have your list, note how much time you'd like to allocate for each activity in a typical week.

Activity	Time I'd Like To Allocate Weekly
i.e. time with close friends	*2 hours every week*

Sync With Stakeholders At Work

Remember this:

- ❑ **Syncing your schedule with stakeholders at work is critical for making time for traction in your day.**
  Without visibility into how you spend your time, colleagues and managers are more likely to distract you with superfluous tasks.

- ❑ **Sync as frequently as your schedule changes.**
  If your schedule template changes from day to day, have a daily check-in. However, most people find a weekly alignment is sufficient.

Note: Make sure you read the twelfth chapter of Indistractable to fully understand these concepts before completing the exercises.

Exercise 12

1) Name the activities you want to do every week in the work domain of your life. List all the things that serve your values of being a team player, industrious, and persistent.

Review your list and make sure you've included reflexive work (e.g., answering messages, attending meetings, and answering calls) in addition to focused work (e.g., working on a long term project, preparing a presentation).

Sync With Stakeholders At Work (cont.)

2) Now that you have your list, note how much time you'd like to allocate for each activity in a typical week in a manner that is consistent with your values and the value you bring to your company.

Activity	Time I'd Like To Allocate Weekly
i.e., time for strategic thinking	*2 hours every week*

3) Take some time to look at your schedule as a game or puzzle. The pieces of the puzzle are the time blocks you've now identified in each of your three life domains (you, relationships, work). Much like the game of Tetris, the mission is to arrange and rearrange the pieces of the puzzle in order to fit them into your schedule. Think creatively about how you can make things work. For example, what tasks can you eliminate or outsource? What tasks will you spend less time on? What tasks will you spend more time on? Can you batch similar tasks together?

   Eliminate your preconceived notions of what an ordinary day should look like. After all, this is your game, your life, and, therefore, your rules.

   (Use the Schedule Template in Indistractable of this free schedule maker tool to construct your day: http://nirandfar.com/schedule-maker)

Part 3:

Hack Back External Triggers

Ask The Critical Question

Remember this:

- ❑ **External triggers often lead to distraction.**
  Cues in our environment like the pings, dings, and rings from devices, as well as interruptions
  from other people, frequently take us off track.

- ❑ **External triggers aren't always harmful.**
  If an external trigger leads us to traction, it serves us.

- ❑ **We must ask ourselves: Is this trigger serving me, or am I serving it?**
  Then we can hack back the external triggers that don't serve us.

Note: Make sure you read the thirteenth chapter of Indistractable to fully understand these concepts before completing the exercises on the following page.

Ask The Critical Question (cont.)

Exercise 13

1) Set a timer for 3 minutes and write down all the external triggers you experience in a typical day. Consider the external triggers that get your attention at home, at work, or with your family. Then, next to each external trigger, note whether the trigger served you (i.e., led to traction) or whether you served the trigger (i.e., led to distraction).

External Trigger	Trigger Served Me ✓	I Served the Trigger ✓
i.e Morning Alarm Clock	✓	
i.e Phone Call During Work		✓

Hack Back Work Interruptions

Remember this:

- ❑ **Interruptions lead to mistakes.**
  You can't do your best work if you're frequently distracted.

- ❑ **Open-office floor plans increase distraction.**

- ❑ **Defend your focus.**
  Signal when you do not want to be interrupted. Use a screen sign or some other clear cue to let people know you are indistractable.

Note: Make sure you read the fourteenth chapter of Indistractable to fully understand these concepts before completing the exercises.

Exercise 14

1) Who tends to interrupt you in person most frequently while you're working? Imagine the additional traction you could achieve each day in the absence of those interruptions.

2) What cues will you use to let colleagues or family members know that you cannot be interrupted?

3) Download your indistractable screen sign to make it clear when you're doing focused work at NirAndFar.com/Indistractable

Hack Back Email

Remember this:

- ❑ **Break down the problem.**
  Time spent on email (T) is a function of the number of messages received (n) multiplied by the average time (t) spent per message.

- ❑ **Reduce the number of messages received.**
  Schedule office hours, delay when messages are sent, and reduce time-wasting messages from reaching your inbox.

- ❑ **Spend less time on each message.**
  Label emails by when each message needs a response. Reply to emails during a scheduled time in your calendar.

Note: Make sure you read the fifteenth chapter of Indistractable to fully understand these concepts before completing the exercises.

Exercise 15

1) Immediately after reading each of your emails, ask yourself, 'When does this person need a response?' and label each message either 'Today' and 'This Week.'

2) Set aside time in your timeboxed schedule to respond to urgent emails every day and less urgent messages during a longer time block every week. Resist the urge to respond to emails immediately.

Hack Back Email (cont.)

3) Minimize the total number of messages received by making time for “office hours,” when you can address time sensitive questions in person. Write down the name(s) of frequent emailers for whom this tactic would be appropriate.

4) To reduce the email ping-pong game, get to know the delay delivery feature in Microsoft Office or try Mixmax for Gmail. Before sending a message, ask yourself, ‘When’s the latest this person needs to see this reply?’ and delay delivery for later instead of sending right away.

5) Religiously unsubscribing from newsletters or other messages that don’t provide value. Use tools like SaneBox to make sure persistent emailers never reach your inbox again.

Hack Back Group Chat

Remember this:

- ❑ **Real-time communication channels should be used sparingly.**
  Time spent communicating should not come at the sacrifice of time spent concentrating.

- ❑ **Company culture matters.**
  Changing group chat practices may involve questioning company norms.

- ❑ **Different communication channels have different uses.**
  Rather than use every technology as an always-on channel, use the best tools for the job.

- ❑ **Get in and get out.**
  Group chat is great for replacing in-person meetings but terrible if it becomes an all-day affair.

Note: Make sure you read the sixteenth chapter of Indistractable to fully understand these concepts before completing the exercises.

Exercise 16

Recall the last notification you received from your group chat app and answer the following questions.

1) What were you working on when you received the notification?

Hack Back Group Chat (cont.)

2) How did the notification make you feel?

3) Did the notification take you away from focused work?

4) How did you respond to the notification?

5) Did this external trigger serve you (and move you towards traction), or did you serve it (and move you towards distraction)?

Set expectations with colleagues by letting them know that you have set aside time in your calendar for group chat and, consequently, may not always be available to participate in the discussion.

In an effort to stay indistractable, remove group chat's external triggers by turning on your Do Not Disturb feature within the app until you are ready to participate.

Hack Back Meetings

Remember this:

- ❑ **Make it harder to call a meeting.**
  To call a meeting, the organizer must circulate an agenda and briefing document.

- ❑ **Meetings are for consensus building.**
  With few exceptions, creative problem-solving should occur before the meeting, individually or in very small groups.

- ❑ **Be fully present.**
  People use devices during meetings to escape monotony and boredom, which subsequently makes meetings even worse.

- ❑ **Have one laptop per meeting.**
  Devices in everyone's hands makes it more difficult to achieve the purpose of the meeting. With the exception of one laptop in the room for presenting information and taking notes, leave devices outside.

Note: Make sure you read the seventeenth chapter of Indistractable to fully understand these concepts before completing the exercises.

Exercise 17

1) Discuss the benefits of distraction-free meetings with your colleagues. What were their reactions?

Hack Back Meetings (cont.)

2) Propose the idea of a screen-free environment for your next team meeting, complete with a device charging station to ensure everyone's presence in both body and mind. What impact did having everyone's full attention have on the effectiveness of the meeting?

If you don't feel comfortable asking your colleagues to try something new, experiment with how leaving your own devices at your desk changes your participation and concentration during meetings.

Hack Back Your Smartphone

Remember this:

- ❑ **You can hack back the external triggers on your phone in four steps and in less than one hour.**
- ❑ **Remove:** Uninstall the apps you no longer need.
- ❑ **Replace:** Shift where and when you use potentially distracting apps, like social media and YouTube, to your desk instead of on your phone. Get a wristwatch so you don't have to look at your phone for the time.
- ❑ **Rearrange:** Move any apps that may trigger mindless checking from your phone's home screen.
- ❑ **Reclaim:** Change the notification settings for each app. Be very selective regarding which apps can send you sound and sight cues. Learn to use your phone's Do Not Disturb settings.

Note: Make sure you read the eighteenth chapter of Indistractable to fully understand these concepts before completing the exercises.

Exercise 18

1) Your smartphone is a device that should be there to serve you, not the other way around. Determine whether it's time for you to finally regain control over your smartphone. If so, timebox 1 hour to hack back.

Hack Back Your Smartphone (cont.)

2) Decrease visual clutter and potential sources of unnecessary external triggers by removing apps you no longer need or no longer align with your values. Don't worry—if you decide that you need them later, you can always reinstall them as needed. List a few of the apps you uninstalled here:

3) Reduce the number of times you check your phone by replacing any frequent behaviors that you currently perform on your phone with another medium (e.g., wear a wristwatch instead of using your phone to tell time, carry a small notebook and pen to jot down short notes rather than opening an app).

4) Declutter your home screen to create a less distracting environment every time you unlock it. Review the apps that are left on your smartphone and sort them into three categories listed below. Then, rearrange your home screen so that the "slot machine" type apps are out of sight.

   Primary Tools (i.e., utility apps to accomplish specific tasks):

   Aspirations (i.e., apps to accomplish goals):

   Slot Machines (i.e., apps that often distract you):

5) Minimize the rings, dings, and pings coming from you phone by disabling unnecessary sound and sight notifications for each app. While this may take a bit of time, the benefits are priceless.

Hack Back Your Desktop

Remember this:

- ❑ **Desktop clutter takes a heavy psychological toll on your attention.**
  Clearing away external triggers in your digital workspace can help you stay focused.

- ❑ **Turn off desktop notifications.**
  Disabling notifications on your computer ensures you won't get distracted by external triggers while doing focused work.

> *Note: Make sure you read the nineteenth chapter of Indistractable to fully understand these concepts before completing the exercises.*

Exercise 19

1) Turn on your laptop/computer desktop and mark the following statements True or False.

   T F My desktop is organized in a manner that helps me stay focused.
   T F My files and documents are tucked away in folders so they don't distract me.
   T F I'm not interrupted by unwanted desktop notifications alerting me of software updates, chat requests, etc.

2) Everybody loves a great Before/After photo. Take a screenshot of your current desktop to serve as your "Before" photo.

3) If you answered False to any of the above statements, make room in your schedule to take the necessary steps to create an indistractable desktop. This will include decluttering your files, adjusting your system preferences to control notifications, and if your feeling particularly motivated, finding a wallpaper that will inspire you to be indistractable.

Hack Back Your Desktop (cont.)

4) When you're ready, take an "After" screenshot of your indistractable desktop. How does your new desktop make you feel?

Hack Back Online Articles

Remember this:

- ❑ **Online articles are full of potentially distracting external triggers.**
  Open tabs can pull us off course and tend to suck us down a time-wasting content vortex.

- ❑ **Make a rule.**
  Promise yourself you'll save interesting content for later by using an app like Pocket**.**

- ❑ **Surprise! You can multitask.**
  Use multichannel multitasking like listening to articles while working out or taking walking meetings.

Note: Make sure you read the twentieth chapter of Indistractable to fully understand these concepts before completing the exercises.

Exercise 20

1) Head to your laptop and open your web browser. Count the number of browser tabs you have open and determine whether those tabs were essential the task you were trying to complete before closing your laptop.

   How many tabs do you have open?

   How many of your tabs pertain to the task that you are working on today?

Hack Back Online Articles (cont.)

2) Install an app like Pocket that allows you to time-shift when and how you read or view content online.

3) Enjoy the positive effects of “temptation bundling” by leveraging your desire to listen to or view your saved online content as motivation to perform another activity. List some of those (perhaps lackluster) activities below (i.e., folding the laundry, waiting for the bus, working out).

Hack Back Your Feeds

Remember this:

- ❑ **Feeds, like the ones we scroll through on social media, are designed to keep you engaged.**
  Feeds are full of external triggers that can drive us to distraction.

- ❑ **Take control of feeds by hacking back.**
  Use free browser extensions like News Feed Eradicator for Facebook, Newsfeed Burner, Open Multiple Websites, and DF Tube to remove distracting external triggers. (Links to all these services and more are available at NirAndFar.com/Indistractable)

Note: Make sure you read the twenty-first chapter of Indistractable to fully understand these concepts before completing the exercises.

Exercise 21

1) List the sites with feeds you use most frequently (e.g., Instagram, Facebook, YouTube, Twitter, LinkedIn, etc.):

For each of the sites, implement browser extensions like the ones described above to help you regain control over your feeds, rather than letting the feeds control you.

Part 4:

Prevent Distraction With Pacts

The Power Of Precommitments

Remember this:

- ❑ **Being indistractable does not only require keeping distractions out.**
  It also necessitates reining ourselves in**.**

- ❑ **Precommitments can reduce the likelihood of distraction.**
  They help us stick with decisions we've made in advance**.**

- ❑ **Precommitments should only be used after the other three indistractable strategies have already been applied.**
  Don't skip the first three steps**.**

Note: Make sure you read the twenty-second chapter of Indistractable to fully understand these concepts before completing the exercises.

Exercise 22

1) Recall a precommitment you made that successfully moved you towards traction in the "You" domain (e.g., enrolled in college, signing up for ten sessions with a personal trainer, etc). Why do you think this precommitment worked for you?

The Power Of Precommitments (cont.)

2) Recall a precommitment you made that successfully moved you towards traction in the “Relationship” domain (e.g., booking a babysitter ahead of time to allow you and your partner to take a date night). Why do you think this worked for you?

3) Recall a precommitment you made that successfully moved you towards traction in the “Work” domain (e.g., volunteering to present a new product feature at an upcoming team retreat in order to assure an on-time delivery). Why do you think this worked for you?

Prevent Distraction With Effort Pacts

Remember this:

- ❑ **An effort pact prevents distraction by making unwanted behaviors more difficult to do.**

- ❑ **In the age of the personal computer, social pressure to stay on task has largely disappeared.**
  No one can see what you're working on, so it's easier to slack off. Working next to a colleague or friend for a set period of time can be a highly effective effort pact.

- ❑ **You can use tech to stay off tech.**
  Apps like SelfControl, Forest, and Focusmate can help you make effort pacts.

Note: Make sure you read the twenty-third chapter of Indistractable to fully understand these concepts before completing the exercises.

Exercise 23

1) Recall the last time you found yourself distracted. What unintended behavior did you perform instead of staying on track?

2) Using the above as an example, how might you use an effort pact to fend off distraction and make you less likely to do something you later regret?

Prevent Distraction With Effort Pacts (cont.)

3) List a long term project or goal you are working on. Name one person you can ask to enter into an effort pact with you to help you stay on track to complete the task and prevent distraction.

4) Try tools like SelfControl, Freedom, Forest, FocusMate.com, and other precommitment tools to make it harder to access the distractions.

Prevent Distraction With Price Pacts

Remember this:

- ❑ **A price pact adds a cost to getting distracted.**
  It has been shown to be a highly effective motivator.

- ❑ **Price pacts are most effective when you can remove the external triggers that lead to distraction.**

- ❑ **Price pacts work best when the distraction is temporary.**

- ❑ **Price pacts can be difficult to start.**
  We fear making a price pact because we know we'll have to actually do the thing we're scared to do.

- ❑ **Learn self-compassion before making a price pact.**

Note: Make sure you read the twenty-fourth chapter of Indistractable to fully understand these concepts before completing the exercises.

Exercise 24

1) Name one behavior or action you'd like to follow through on, but keep getting distracted from doing.

   What is the intended behavior?

Prevent Distraction With Price Pacts (cont.)

Given the criteria described in this chapter for when using a price pact is a good idea, do you think using a price pact, in this case, could be useful?

Note how you feel about making a price pact for your goal. If you feel trepidation, know that's perfectly normal. Reaffirm what you hope to gain by making a price pact by writing it down below.

2) Betting on your own success is shown to be a highly effective commitment strategy. When you're ready, state a wager you are willing to make as part of your price pact.

If I don't _____,
(behavior you promise you'll do)

I will lose _____.
(wager)

Prevent Distraction With Identity Pacts

Remember this:

- ❑ **Identity greatly influences our behavior.**
  People tend to align their actions with how they see themselves.

- ❑ **An identity pact is a precommitment to a self-image.**
  You can prevent distraction by acting in line with your identity.

- ❑ **Become a noun.**
  By assigning yourself a moniker, you increase the likelihood of following through with behaviors consistent with what you call yourself. Call yourself "indistractable."

- ❑ **Share with others.**
  Teaching others solidifies your commitment, even if you're still struggling. A great way to be indistractable is to tell friends about what you learned in this book and the changes you're making in your life.

- ❑ **Adopt rituals.**
  Repeating mantras, keeping a timeboxed schedule, or performing other routines reinforces your identity and influences your future actions.

Note: Make sure you read the twenty-fifth chapter of Indistractable to fully understand these concepts before completing the exercises.

Exercise 25

1) Write 'I am Indistractable' in the space below. Be proud of your new identity!

Prevent Distraction With Identity Pacts (cont.)

2) Name one person who could benefit from hearing more about the benefits of being indistractable. Write down when and where you will talk to them about what you've learned.

3) Name three ways you can remind yourself of your new identity as an indistractable person. For example, you could set a reminder to repeat the words 'I am indistractable' first thing in the morning or when you sit down at your desk. Come up with a few more ideas.

Part 5:

How to Make Your Workplace Indistractable

Distraction Is A Sign Of Dysfunction

Remember this:

- ❑ **Jobs where employees encounter high expectations and low control have been shown to lead to symptoms of depression.**

- ❑ **Depression-like symptoms are painful.**
  When people feel bad, they use distractions to avoid their pain and regain a sense of control.

- ❑ **Tech overuse at work is a symptom of a dysfunctional company culture.**

- ❑ **More tech use makes the underlying problems worse, perpetuating a "cycle of responsiveness."**.

Note: Make sure you read the twenty-sixth chapter of Indistractable to fully understand these concepts before completing the exercises.

Exercise 26

1) Indicate the extent to which you agree with the following statements (0 - Do Not at All Agree, 10 - Very Strongly Agree):

   My manager, colleagues, and clients have very high expectations of me.

   0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

   I do not have much control over the outcome of what I do at work.

   0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

Distraction Is A Sign Of Dysfunction (cont.)

My company culture expects me to respond to emails and other messages 24/7/365

0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

My manager often interrupts my workday with random requests, unannounced meetings, and frequently asks me to work late at the last minute.

0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

I do not feel my company's management asks for or listens to my suggestions.

0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

2) Based on your answers above, consider whether your workplace culture perpetuates distraction. A high score indicates you may work in a dysfunctional work environment. If so, name some examples of how you or your colleagues get distracted at work in an effort to alleviate stress or psychological discomfort.

Fixing Distraction Is A Test Of Company Culture

Remember this:

- ❑ **Don't suffer in silence.**
  A workplace where people can't talk about technology overuse is also one where people keep other important issues (and insights) to themselves.

- ❑ **Knowing that your voice matters is essential.**
  Teams that foster psychological safety and facilitate regular open discussions about concerns not only have fewer problems with distraction but also have happier employees and customers.

Note: Make sure you read the twenty-seventh chapter of Indistractable to fully understand these concepts before completing the exercises.

Exercise 27

1) Discussing team and personal wins, mistakes, and areas of improvement on a regular basis can foster psychological safety. To give you a sense of your psychological safety in the context of your workplace, indicate the extent to which you agree with the following statements (0 - Do Not at All Agree, 10 - Very Strongly Agree):

   I feel safe to discuss a mistake I made on a recent project without fear I'll get fired.

   0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

   I feel comfortable asking my colleagues for help and do not think this will be viewed negatively by others.

   0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

Fixing Distraction Is A Test Of Company Culture (cont.)

I feel comfortable letting my team know that I do not know the answer.

0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

I feel comfortable bringing up areas of improvement in our work processes.

0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

Tabulate your number score. A higher score indicates your workplace provides psychological safety while a lower score indicates your work environment may not make you feel psychologically safe.

Based on your answers above, consider whether you and your colleagues can benefit from opening a dialogue through regular meetings similar to the ones conducted at BCG.

The Indistractable Workplace

Remember this:

- ❑ **Indistractable organizations, like Slack and BCG, foster psychological safety, provide a place for open discussions about concerns, and, most important, have leaders who exemplify the importance of doing focused work.**

Note: Make sure you read the twenty-eighth chapter of Indistractable to fully understand these concepts before completing the exercises.

Exercise 28

1) Our everyday actions contribute to a workplace culture that can either support or discourage distraction. Perform a brief assessment of your behaviors at work, as well as those of your management team, by indicating the extent to which you agree with the following statements (0 - Do Not at All Agree, 10 - Very Strongly Agree):

   I intentionally timebox opportunities for focused, uninterrupted work.

   0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

   My manager respects my need for focused, uninterrupted work and does not often override my calendar with last minute meetings or unannounced visits to my desk.

   0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

   I do not send or respond to emails and messages after hours, on weekends, or on vacation unless it is essential to business needs and previously timeboxed in my schedule.

   0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

The Indistractable Workplace (cont.)

I have a safe place to discuss concerns with leadership about workplace culture.

0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

Management acknowledges and respects our feedback about workplace culture.

0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

2) Tabulate your score from the questions above. A higher score indicates a healthier work culture while a lower score indicates a workplace that perpetuates distraction.

   If your work environment is dysfunctional, is not willing to engender open discussion about the company's problems, and you're not in a position to change it, consider other options for the sake of your health and sanity.

3) Share *Indistractable*, or excerpts of it, with others on your team or with your managers. Share the company success stories in particular to encourage them to consider creating a workplace culture that fosters traction and minimizes distraction.

Part 6:

How to Raise Indistractable Children

(and Why We All Need Psychological Nutrients)

Avoid Convenient Excuses

Remember this:

- ❑ **Stop deflecting blame.**
  When children don't act the way parents want, it's natural to look for answers that help parents divert responsibility.

- ❑ **Techno-panics are nothing new.**
  From the book, to the radio, to video games, the history of parenting is strewn with moral panic over things supposedly making kids act in strange ways.

- ❑ **Tech isn't evil.**
  Used in the right way and in the right amounts, kids' tech use can be beneficial, while too much (or too little) can have slightly harmful effects.

- ❑ **Teach kids to be indistractable.**
  Teaching children how to manage distraction will benefit them throughout their lives.

Note: Make sure you read the twenty-ninth chapter of Indistractable to fully understand these concepts before completing the exercises.

Exercise 29

1) Have you found yourself associating your child's undesirable behavior with technology overuse? If so, describe the undesirable behavior(s) below.

Avoid Convenient Excuses (cont.)

2) Why do you associate the undesirable behavior with the use of technology? Are there other potential factors contributing to these behaviors?

3) Recall something from your childhood that your parents often restricted your use of. (e.g., rap music, comic books, television, Nintendo, etc).

4) How did your parents control your use of any of these things and how did it make you feel towards them? How did it make you feel towards the thing they restricted?

Understand Their Internal Triggers

Remember this:

- ❑ **Internal triggers drive behavior.**
  To understand how to help kids manage distraction, we need to start by understanding the source of the problem.

- ❑ **Our kids need psychological nutrients.**
  According to a widely accepted theory of human motivation, all people need three things to thrive: a sense of autonomy, competence, and relatedness.

- ❑ **Distractions satisfy deficiencies.**
  When our kids' psychological needs are not met in the real world, they go looking for satisfaction—often in virtual environments.

- ❑ **Kids need alternatives.**
  Parents and guardians can take steps to help kids find balance between their online and offline worlds by providing more offline opportunities to find autonomy, competence, and relatedness.

- ❑ **The four-part Indistractable Model is valuable for kids as well.**
  Teach them methods for handling distraction, and, most important, model being indistractable yourself.

Note: Make sure you read the thirtieth chapter of Indistractable to fully understand these concepts before completing the exercises on the following pages.

Understand Their Internal Triggers (cont.)

Exercise 30

1) Observe how much time your child is spending with digital devices after school. Do you feel that this amount is excessive? Why?

2) Understanding the internal triggers that drive the behaviors of our kids is the first step to raising indistractable kids. Indicate the extent to which you agree with the following statements (0 - Do Not at All Agree, 10 - Very Strongly Agree):

   My child has a high level of autonomy and freedom with regards to what and how she/he learns at school each day.

   0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

   My child is given many opportunities to be creative and solve problems on their own throughout her/his day.

   0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

   My child does not feel overly restricted throughout her/his day.

   0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

   My child has many opportunities to build self-directed competency through her/his day.

   0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

Understand Their Internal Triggers (cont.)

My child is given many opportunities to play with other kids, free from being told what to do by teachers, coaches, and parents.

0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

3) Open a dialogue with your kid(s) to better understand their internal trigger(s). Ask them to indicate the extent to which they agree with the following statements; be sure to avoid placing judgement upon their answers, as this is an opportunity to build trust for all parties: (Note: you may have to explain what some of these words mean to younger children. Feel free to ask in your own words to get a sense of what's really going on.) (0 - Do Not at All Agree, 10 - Very Strongly Agree):

I have a high level of autonomy and freedom with regards to what and how I learn at school each day.

0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

I am given many opportunities to be creative and solve problems on my own throughout my day.

0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

I do not feel overly restricted throughout my day.

0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

I have many opportunities to build competency and get better at things I enjoy through my day.

0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

I am given plenty of time to play with others kids, without being told what to do by teachers, coaches, and parents.

0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

Understand Their Internal Triggers (cont.)

4) Calculate the scores from the questions above. A high score indicates your child is likely getting sufficient amounts of autonomy and competence. A low score indicates they may be looking for these missing “psychological nutrients.

   Is there a gap between the score for the first set of questions and the second set? If so, explore this difference in perception with your child.

   Based on your responses and those of your kid(s) to the statements above, what can you do to foster an environment that can provide more psychological nutrients for your kid(s) (e.g., provide more time for unstructured play, give them opportunities to improve at a skill of their choice, etc.)?

5) Share the four-part indistractable framework discussed in this book. Let them know the steps you’re taking to remove unhelpful distractions from your life and set a good example.

Make Time For Traction Together

Remember this:

- ❑ **Teach traction.**
  With so many potential distractions in kids' lives, teaching them how to make time for traction is critical.

- ❑ **Just as with our own timeboxed schedules, kids can learn how to make time for what's important to them.**
  If they don't learn to make their own plans in advance, kids will turn to distractions.

- ❑ **It's OK to let your kids fail.**
  Failure is how we learn. Show kids how to adjust their schedules to make time to live up to their values.

Note: Make sure you read the thirty-first chapter of Indistractable to fully understand these concepts before completing the exercises.

Exercise 31

The following activities can be done with your child. Their involvement in this activity can give them a greater sense of autonomy over how their time is spent.

1) List all the activities that serve the values of physical health, wellness, and personal growth. (e.g., time for sleep, healthy eating, exercise, and personal development and learning.) If s/he enjoys activities like watching television, browsing the web, watching videos on YouTube, or just vegging out, consider whether they align with their values, and if so, write them down as well.

Make Time For Traction Together (cont.)

2) Name the activities s/he wants to do with or for the important people in her/his life every week. List all the things that serve her/his values of connection, closeness, equality, and friendship. (e.g., time for playing with friends and time for playing with family.)

3) Name the activities s/he wants to do every week in the work/school domain of her/his life. List all the things that serve her/his values of being persistent, competent, or other values.

4) Now that you have her/his list, note how much time s/he'd like to allocate for each activity in a typical week.

Activity	Time I'd Like To Allocate Weekly

Make Time For Traction Together (cont.)

5) It's time to play (with your kid). Treating her/his schedule template as a game or puzzle, think of the pieces of the puzzle as the time blocks you've identified in each of her/his three life domains above. Like a game of Tetris, the mission is to arrange and rearrange the pieces of the puzzle in order to fit them into her/his schedule.

   Think creatively about how you can make things work. What tasks will s/he spend less time on? What tasks will s/he spend more time on? When possible, eliminate any preconceived notions of what an ordinary day should look like. Let their values guide you.

   You can find a free online schedule maker tool here: https://nirandfar.com/schedule-maker/

   Don't forget to make time to help your child reflect and refine her/his calendar template to adjust how much time s/he allocates to each activity in the week ahead.

Help Them With External Triggers

Remember this:

- ❑ **Teach your children to swim before they dive in.**
  Like swimming in a pool, children should not be allowed to partake in certain risky behaviors before they are ready.

- ❑ **Test for tech readiness.**
  A good measure of a child's readiness is the ability to manage distraction by using the settings on the device to turn off external triggers.

- ❑ **Kids need sleep.**
  There is little justification for having a television or other potential distractions in a kid's room overnight. Make sure nothing gets in the way of them getting good rest.

- ❑ **Don't be the unwanted external trigger.**
  Respect their time and don't interrupt them when they have scheduled time to focus on something, be that work or play.

Note: Make sure you read the thirty-second chapter of Indistractable to fully understand these concepts before completing the exercises.

Exercise 32

1) Consider your child's ability to manage digital distraction on their own by indicating the extent to which you agree with the following statements (0 - Do Not at All Agree, 10 - Very Strongly Agree):

   My child understands and is able to utilize the built-in settings to turn off external triggers on her/his smartphone.

   0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

Help Them With External Triggers (cont.)

My child consistently places her/his smartphone out of sight during family time or when friends
come over.

0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

My child's smartphone does not get in the way of her/his actions that demand concentration.

0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

Calculate your score on the questions above. A high score indicates your child is able to turn off external triggers while I low score indicates they may not yet developed the skills to put distractions in their place.

Based on your responses above, determine whether your child may need a few more "swim lessons" regarding how to use technology appropriately.

2) Answer True or False to the following statements about the removal of other common external triggers in your child's environment:

T F My child does not have any digital screens in her/his room overnight.
T F My child does not have a television in her/his room.
T F My child is very rarely interrupted during her/his time of focused work time with doorbells, phone calls, unannounced discussions, etc.
T F All members of the household are respectful of my child's timeboxed schedule and are committed to helping her/him live out her values by removing unwanted external triggers.

3) Make sure you know what your child is doing online. There are many free monitoring tools for making sure your child isn't wandering into the 'deep end of the pool' before they're ready.

Teach Them To Make Their Own Pacts

Remember this:

- ❑ **Don't underestimate your child's ability to precommit and follow through.**
  Even young children can learn to use precommitments as long as they set the rules and know how to use a timer or some other binding system.

- ❑ **Consumer skepticism is healthy.**
  Understanding that companies are motivated to keep kids spending time watching or playing is an important part of teaching media literacy.

- ❑ **Put the kids in charge.**
  It's only when kids practice monitoring their own behavior that they learn how to manage their own time and attention.

Note: Make sure you read the thirty-third chapter of Indistractable to fully understand these concepts before completing the exercises.

Exercise 33

1) Ask your child to recall the last time s/he found her/himself distracted. What unintended behavior did s/he do instead of staying on track? Ask yourself the same question and share your responses.

   Instead of _____,
   (insert his/her intended action)

   I found myself _____.
   (insert his/her actual action)

Teach Them To Make Their Own Pacts (cont.)

2) Using the above as an example, work with your child to identify how s/he might use a precommitment to fend off distraction and make her/him less likely to do something s/he later regrets. Remember to tailor precommitments to the age of your child (e.g., simple tools like timers for young children vs. more sophisticated tools to help older kids enforce their own limits).

3) Be prepared to have discussions, and at times disagreements, about tech use with your child. Involve kids in the decision making and don't be the bad guy. Healthy discussions about whether a child is ready to handle new risks are a vehicle for learning more about the world, both online and offline.

Part 7:

How to Have Indistractable Relationships

Spread Social Antibodies Among Friends

Remember this:

- ❑ **Distraction in social situations can keep us from being fully present with important people in our lives.**
  Interruptions degrade our ability to form close social bonds.

- ❑ **Block the spread of unhealthy behaviors.**
  "Social antibodies" are ways groups protect themselves from harmful behaviors by making them taboo.

- ❑ **Develop new social norms.**
  We can tackle distraction among friends the same way we beat social smoking, by making it unacceptable to use devices in social situations. Prepare a few tactful phrases—like asking, "Is everything OK?"—to discourage phone usage among friends.

Note: Make sure you read the thirty-fourth chapter of Indistractable to fully understand these concepts before completing the exercises.

Exercise 34

1) Social antibodies can make certain undesired behaviors unacceptable. Recall a behavior that you've adopted or changed as a result of the establishment of new social norms (e.g., silencing your phones before a movie, taking your shoes off when entering a home with crawling toddlers, avoiding all caps typing).

Spread Social Antibodies Among Friends (cont.)

2) When was the last time you found yourself in the company of a friend who was engaged with her/his device rather than you (a.k.a. ‘phubbing)? How did you react?

3) Next time you see a friend using a distracting device in a social situation, ask, “I see you’re on your phone. Is everything okay?”

4) When was the last time you found yourself in a social setting full of external triggers? How did that affect your experience with your friends?

5) Make time for distraction-free discussions. Select a venue with minimal external triggers to limit distraction (e.g., avoid restaurants with wall-to-wall televisions, bars with loud music). Name three places you can have distraction-free time with friends.

Be An Indistractable Lover

Remember this:

- ❑ **Distraction can be an impediment in our most intimate relationships.** Instant digital connectivity can come at the expense of being fully present with those beside us.

- ❑ **Indistractable partners reclaim time for togetherness.** Following the four steps to becoming indistractable can ensure you make time for your partner.

- ❑ **Now it's your turn to become indistractable!**

Note: Make sure you read the last chapter of Indistractable to fully understand these concepts before completing the exercises.

Exercise 35

1) Briefly describe your typical evening routine before bed. Note how much time is spent completing work assignments and household chores.

Be An Indistractable Lover (cont.)

2) Are you an indistractable lover? Assess your and your partner's behaviors by indicating the extent to which you agree with the following statements (0 - Do Not at All Agree, 10 - Very Strongly Agree):

   My partner and I use techniques to handle the urge to engage with digital devices (i.e., manage internal triggers).

   0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

   My partner and I have established a bedtime in our schedules and hold each other accountable.

   0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

   My partner and I have removed all external triggers in our bedroom that don't serve our relationship (e.g., digital devices and televisions).

   0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

   When needed, my partner and I leverage precommitment tools to remove external triggers (e.g., Do Not Disturb phone features and timers to shut down internet access).

   0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

   Compute your score. A high score indicates you're likely to have an indistractable relationship. A lower score indicates you may have some opportunities for improvement.

   Based on your responses above, determine whether you and your partner can implement additional tactics to help build an indistractable relationship.

Ever get the feeling the world is full of too many distractions?

For more *Indistractable* tools and resources, visit

indistractable.com